

THE AGE

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TOMORROW

Open Guide

Disaster: Soviets call for help

Thousands evacuated for 30km around N-leak area

LONDON 29 April. — Soviet officials have declared the accident at the Chernobyl nuclear power station in the Ukraine a "disaster" and have cleared an area within a radius of 30 kilometres around the site.

Tens of thousands of people are said to have been evacuated and there were unconfirmed reports of many deaths.

However, Tass news agency said that only two people had died.

The Soviet Union has asked the West for help in putting out the fire at the plant.

Diplomatic sources said the Soviet embassy in Stockholm had approached Sweden's nuclear inspection authority for advice on handling a burning graphite reactor core.

A Soviet diplomat also appeared at a centre run by West Germany's atomic energy industry in Bonn, seeking urgent advice on how to fight a similar fire.

The nuclear power station accident, disclosed yesterday, is the most serious in the history of nuclear power generation, British experts believe.

3300m REPORT

Scandinavian readings today showed a decline in radioactivity. The international Atomic Energy Agency in Vienna said it had been notified of the accident, involving a 1600 megawatt reactor, in of major proportions. The BBC news service said it was about 3300 metres in the air. The US presidential Chief of Staff, Mr Donald Regan, on his way to the accident site, reported to have offered American help. Riga's nuclear power plant, Sweden, measured 100 times the normal amount of caesium 137, and high iodine counts were made in central Sweden. Radiation levels in some areas of Finland were reported to be 10 times higher than normal.

um has a half-life of more than 30 years and its presence would indicate high contamination in the area of the accident. Mr Peter Taylor, of the political ecology research group, said the release of 137 would cause long-term, serious health damage. There is speculation that a large-scale evacuation is being carried out from Chernobyl. But services in Kiev are reported to have been disrupted because of the emergency in Chernobyl, 130 kilometres north.

The BBC says the first reports of high radiation over Scandinavia came early on Sunday afternoon, indicating that the accident probably happened on Saturday morning.

A spokesman at the Danish nuclear laboratory at Risø said: "It is difficult to say exactly what happened. We are looking at something very close to a meltdown. A Swedish nuclear inspector said the accident appeared to have been caused by the overheating of nuclear fuel. A considerable explosion would have been caused, and there was a danger of a meltdown of the nuclear core of the reactor."

Sweden first learned of the high radiation level when a worker at the Forsmark nuclear plant, about 90 kilometres north of Stockholm, set off an alarm while routing through a routine radiation check. Six hundred workers were evacuated, but tests showed there had been no leak from the plant. Sweden asked Moscow for an estimate of nuclear power at the site. The Swedish embassy in Moscow was warned of any nuclear accident that could cause a leak to reach Sweden.

The Swedish Energy Minister, Mr Birgitta Dahl, said last night that Sweden was not satisfied with Soviet behaviour. "They should have notified us immediately," she said. "We must demand higher safety standards in the Soviet Union."

Mr Dahl urged that all Soviet reactors be placed under international control, although adding that there was no danger of radiation in Sweden from the present leak. An Energy Ministry spokesman said that the rate of "a few millirems an hour" was not high enough to warrant the evacuation of the area.

X-ray. The British Radiological Protection Board said Britain would not be affected.

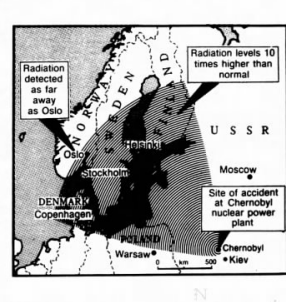
The Tass report of the accident said: "Measures are being taken to eliminate the consequences of the accident. Aid is being given to those affected." A government inquiry had been set up, it added.

The report was mentioned on Soviet television last night but did not appear in newspapers this morning. It referred to similar accidents in other countries, claiming it was the first of its kind in the Soviet Union.

Mystery still surrounds a serious accident reported in the Urals in the late 1970s when radioactive waste was thought to have died from radiation after an explosion of buried nuclear waste.

America's worst nuclear accident was in 1979 at Three Mile Island, Pennsylvania, when radioactive and leaked after a partial meltdown of a reactor. About 14,000 people were evacuated. The Soviet admission took Western diplomats by surprise. National disasters are seldom reported unless loss of life is large or the impact is involved.

PAGE 1: Further could rule Ukraine's harvest.



Clip, clop, clatter, here comes the coachbuilder

Bernie Dingle is probably the last of Melbourne's coachbuilders.

Mr Dingle has never had a car, hasn't a driver's licence and isn't the least interested in getting one. Instead, Mr Dingle, his wife Francis and their six-year-old son Edward travel about by horse and bridle. As with the movies, for instance, simply means parking the horse outside the cinema.

His two large brown horses, O'Reilly and Nugget, are kept in quiet stables down a laneway just bounded by the remnants of backyards from another era.

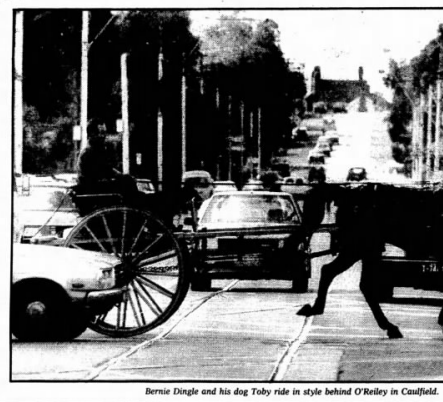
Mr Dingle's love of horses and horse-drawn vehicles took shape when, at the age of 12, he saw his father's coachbuilding factory in the city.

Eventually, Mr Knight took on the youngster to pass on the secret of his father's life in the early days of the century. "He (Mr Dingle) was the best apprentice I have had," Mr Knight said.

The pair built the four-horse Cartan and United Breweries wagon and used to exhibit at the Melbourne Show in the tradesmen's driveway before the trade, isn't exactly booming. "It is a beautiful trade but it died out in many ways," Mr Dingle said.

He survives on private work, repairing horse-drawn vehicles and sometimes he also has a superb 1936-vintage carriage he built about five years ago, which he drives for weddings. Mr Dingle drives the truck to transport the horses to distant engagements.

CLAIRE MILLER



Bernie Dingle and his dog Toby ride in style behind O'Reilly in Caulfield.

Picture: MARK WILSON

Wran says he would like to see Briese sacked

By ROBERT WHITEHEAD
and MICHELLE GRATTAN
in Canberra

The New South Wales Premier, Mr Wran, said yesterday he would like to see the State Attorney-General, Mr Justice Murphy, removed from office.

Mr Wran, in a broad attack in Parliament, said he would not be happy with the administration of justice in NSW while Mr Briese stayed.

The criticism followed Mr Wran's comments on the acquittal of Mr Justice Murphy on Monday, when Mr Wran said Mr Briese had not enjoyed his full confidence for some time. Mr Briese was chief witness in the case against the former Premier, Mr Wran, in a broad attack in Parliament, said he would not be happy with the administration of justice in NSW while Mr Briese stayed.

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and against whom "unacceptable" comments had been made. The NSW Bar Association's president, Mr Roger Goss, QC, said yesterday it regarded Mr Wran's comments as "unacceptable" and could only be removed from office by the Governor, upon very strong and limited grounds. Any wrong impression that they are subject to control or dismissal by the Government is most unfortunate.

The Magistrates Institute of NSW expressed "its confidence in Mr Briese's integrity as chief magistrate of NSW and supports him in that role."

Mr Briese would only say that he was seeking legal advice.

In Parliament, Mr Wran said his lack of confidence did not stem from the Murphy case, another case brought against Judge John Murray Ford, of the District Court, after a report by Mr Briese alleged he had sought to influence the outcome of a magistrate's case. Judge Ford was acquitted.

Mr Wran said he was concerned with an alleged relationship Mr Briese had with the Liberal Party, citing an accusation that Mr Briese had obtained transcripts of the NSW police tapes from Liberal frontbencher, Mr Bruce Baird, while the two attended their church.

Continued: PAGE 5
PAGE 12 Editorial

Indonesians order ABC pair out of Bali

By MARK BAKER,
diplomatic correspondent
CANTBERRA. — Two ABC journalists were ordered to fly out of Bali early today after attempting to deny Indonesia's ban on the Australian press.

The journalists were escorted by Indonesian officials on to a Garuda flight to Tokyo two hours after arriving in a press plane accompanying President Regan.

The two ABC Washington correspondents, Richard Palfreyman and Jim Middleton, had been encouraged by US officials to test the Indonesian ban.

In Canberra late last night, the Federal Government called in the deputy head of the Indonesian embassy, Mr Rodolfo Suroto, to protest against the decision. A Foreign Affairs Department spokesman said Mr Suroto was told of Australia's "displeasure" at the ban and remained with the journalists until their flight left for Tokyo about 12.30 am.

The two, who are accredited with the White House press corps but were not carrying personal visas, were warned by Indonesian authorities on Monday not to proceed to Bali. An assistant White House press secretary is reported to have told Middleton: "Come aboard. Let's give it a go. You're welcome to come on."

The US ambassador in Jakarta, Mr Paul Wolfowitz, last night asked Indonesian authorities to allow the reporters to remain in the Regan visit.

Australia's consul in Bali, Mr Kevin McMahon, and his deputy, Mr Bill Richardson, were present at the talks and remained with the journalists until their flight left for Tokyo about 12.30 am.

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INSIDE

Chaos warning
Industrial chaos and heavy costs would follow any attempt to merge Inter-Melbourne trams and a union warned.
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Deeper milk
Milk prices will rise from tomorrow but could fall later in the year.
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Probe challenge
The terms of reference for the inquiry over the murder of striking cameraman Donald Mackay are being challenged.
PAGE 3

Trade row
The Trade Minister, Mr Dawkins, yesterday appeared to deflect Opposition charges in the Mink trade compromise row.
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Teachers' caned
Teachers had to accept responsibility for the poor image of the state school system, the Premier Mr Cain said last night.
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Terror 'link'
A small number of violence-prone immigrants in Australia are linked with extremist overseas, a conference was told yesterday.
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Creditors meet
Creditors of Frontier Homes, which collapsed last month, heard bad news and apocalyptic yesterday.
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'Whit-hunt' alert
A leading criminologist has warned against police campaigns to combat sex abuse of children.
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WORLD

Vigilante attack
At least five people have been killed in a new attack by well-organised vigilantes in a South African black township.
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BUSINESS

Dollar firm
The Australian dollar is worth 72 cents of the dollar, the lowest point yesterday.
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MINI loss
Milk Holdings lost \$15 million in the 1985-86 third quarter, the company said yesterday.
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SPORT

National league
Western Australia is ready to join an expanded 14-side VFL competition next year.
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Galleywood wins
Galleywood won his second Varsity Steeple on his home track at Warrambool.
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ODD SPOT

The audience at a performance of "Waiting for Godot" by a Swedish prize theatre company was left waiting yesterday when the performers all escaped before the show.

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WEATHER

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